



None of the gaps that OEF seeks to fill; in water and sanitation, in clean energy, or in climate resilience can be closed by any single actor working alone. The UN's 2024 [Financing for Sustainable Development Report](#) puts the annual SDG investment gap in developing countries at around US\$4 trillion, up from US\$2.5 trillion in 2019 and equivalent to roughly 4% of global GDP, with energy, water and transport infrastructure among the largest shortfalls. Official development assistance from OECD Development Assistance Committee members reached a record US\$223.7 billion in 2023 still only 0.37% of members' combined national income, well short of the UN's long-standing 0.7% target<sup>1</sup>. The UN Secretary-General has consequently called for a US\$500 billion annual 'SDG Stimulus' precisely because government and donor budgets alone cannot close a gap of this size; closing it requires deliberately mobilising philanthropy, civil society and private capital alongside the public sector, which is the explicit purpose of SDG 17<sup>2</sup>.

Uganda illustrates both the scale of this reliance and its limits. The country received roughly US\$2.26 billion in net official development assistance in 2023, according to World Bank data, funding that touches health, education, infrastructure and humanitarian response across the country<sup>3</sup>. Yet a Development Initiatives review of aid effectiveness in Uganda found that between 2012 and 2021 just 2% of ODA disbursed to the country went to social protection and that the areas of clearest success, such as the national Expanding Social Protection programme, were the ones built on deliberate coordination between government, donors and civil society organisations from the outset, with a clear plan for national ownership over time<sup>4</sup>. The lesson for a young foundation is direct: aid or grant funding alone rarely reaches sustainable outcomes without genuine coordination across government, donors and community-level implementers.

This is why OEF treats partnership not as a supporting activity but as the operating model for its work on water and sanitation (SDG 6), clean energy (SDG 7) and climate resilience (SDG 13) alike. In practice this means co-designing solutions with the communities who will use and maintain them, rather than delivering finished

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<sup>1</sup> See <https://unstats.un.org/sdgs/report/2024/Goal-17/>

<sup>2</sup> See <https://www.un.org/en/node/216607>

<sup>3</sup> See <https://tradingeconomics.com/uganda/net-official-development-assistance-and-official-aid-received-us-dollar-wb-data.html>

<sup>4</sup> See <https://devinit.org/resources/aid-effectiveness-in-uganda-social-protection-in-focus/>

infrastructure to them; working with local and national government so that pilots align with existing policy targets such as Uganda's National Energy Policy and National Energy Compact and have a realistic path to scale; engaging technical and private-sector actors who bring efficiency, innovation and financing that neither government nor communities can supply alone; and partnering with philanthropy and civil society organisations that bring flexible, patient capital and on-the-ground reach into the communities that need it most. Each of these actors holds a different piece of what is needed to close Uganda's WASH, energy and climate financing gaps, and OEF's role is to convene them around shared, locally led solutions.

For OEF, this makes SDG 17 the connective thread running through every other goal in its strategy rather than a separate pillar. OEF will build durable, accountable partnerships with communities, government, technical actors, private-sector partners and philanthropic and civil society funders, structured around shared measurement of results and a clear pathway to local ownership and sustainability. Through these partnerships, OEF will demonstrate practical, measurable and replicable solutions that contribute directly to its commitment to Access, Resilience and Impact.